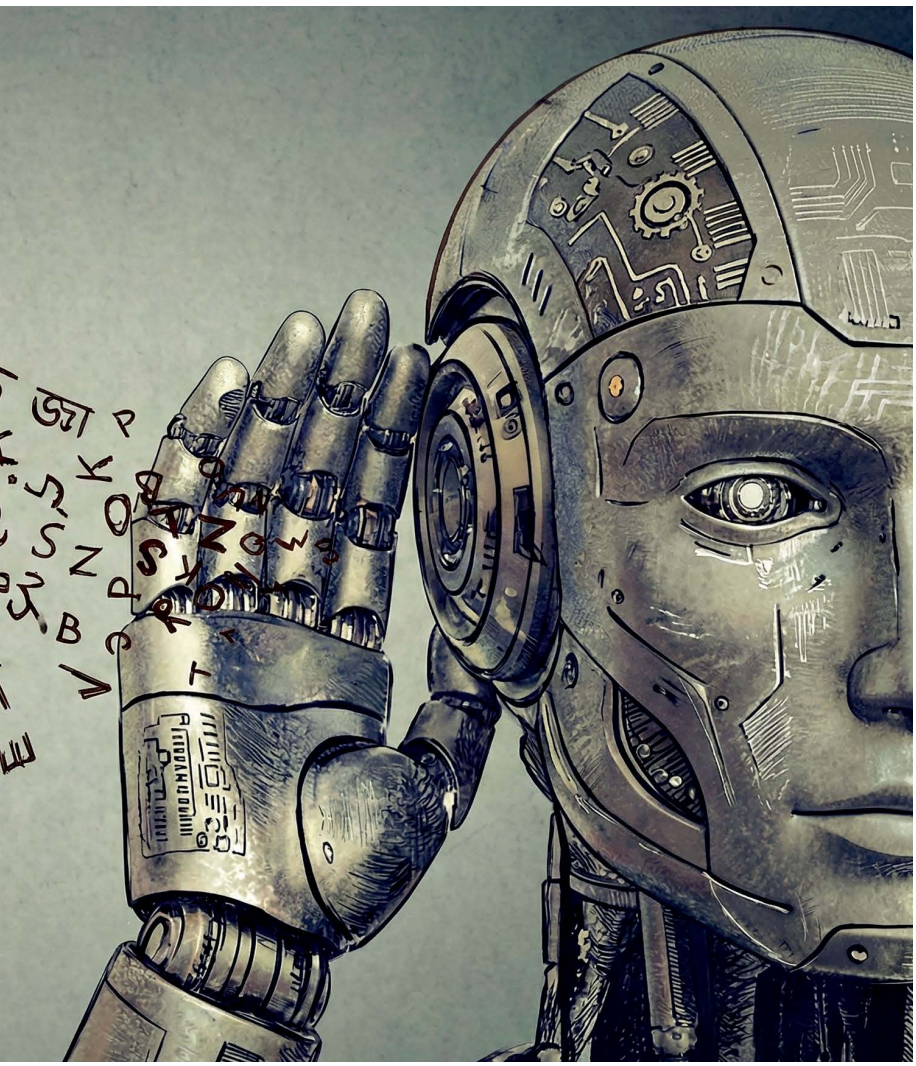


ment platforms, startups and developers to plug vernacular language capabilities into citizen-facing services.

This approach has drawn global attention. The Gates Foundation, for instance, has framed vernacular language technologies—across voice and text—as foundational enablers of inclusive AI in health, education, agriculture and government services. By supporting these capabilities as digital public goods, the emphasis shifts from isolated applications to long-term capacity-building—an approach that mirrors India's own DPI trajectory. Yet scale has also revealed how incomplete India's linguistic maps remain.

Through initiatives such as RESPIN and Project VAANI at IISc's SPIRE Lab, researchers have begun to address one of the deepest gaps in Indian-language AI: the absence of large-scale, representative speech data. These efforts have collected and transcribed speech across hundreds of districts, including languages not even listed in the Census—Agariya, Angika, Bajjika, Bearybashe, Malvani, Paniya, Shekhawati and Sylheti—capturing voices that formal datasets long ignored. Supported by a consortium of partners, including Google, Project VAANI reflects a simple recognition: India will not type its way into AI adoption—it will speak its way in.

But listening is only the first challenge. Understanding is harder. Transcribing Indian-language speech is skilled, interpretive work. Two transcribers often disagree—not because one is wrong, but because variation is intrinsic. Designing evaluation frameworks that respect linguistic diversity rather than suppress it remains one of the hardest problems in vernacular AI.

This is where safety comes sharply into focus. Community-centred efforts such as Karya make the limits of fluent-but-fragile AI especially visible. Karya works with communities across India to build high-quality language datasets, treating contributors as knowledge workers and paying them fairly. Teams working at another initiative, Soket.ai, supported through the IndiaAI Mission, encountered a reality that global systems often overlook: the internet captures only a thin slice of how Indians actually speak. Noise, code-mixing, unstable networks and low-end devices are not edge cases; they are the norm. In India, voice systems succeed not by impressing in demos, but by not breaking in the field.

## Responsible AI

At the frontier of scale sit efforts such as BharatGen and Sarvam AI, signalling that India is no longer content with adapting global models. These initiatives aim to build large, multilingual and multimodal systems grounded in Indian data, scripts and use-cases, particularly for governance and citizen services.

As models grow more powerful, stewardship becomes essential. AI Kosh, another pillar of the IndiaAI Mission, is envisioned as a secure repository of curated datasets, models and benchmarks—enabling reuse while embedding safeguards around consent, privacy and accountability. In a country where language data carries deep social signals, such infrastructure is not overhead; it is protection.

By 2026, vernacular AI systems are likely to move from advisory tools to decision-adjacent infrastructure—embedded deeper into welfare delivery, healthcare triage, grievance redressal and local governance. Voice-first assistants will not just answer questions; they will flag risks, suggest next steps and escalate uncertainty.

Seen in this light, ASHABot is not just an early success. It is a preview of the future. Systems like ASHABot matter not because they always have the right answer, but because they are designed to listen, to reason aloud, and to support—not replace—human judgement. In India, the future of AI will be decided not by how confidently it speaks, but by how carefully it listens. ■

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